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In some sense, cities generate themselves — they are complex, adaptive, self-organizing systems.

Of course, it is actually people who create cities, either individually or as organized into businesses, governments, and other institutions.

But, for the most part, they do so unintentionally as they go about their daily lives.

They move to satisfy immediate needs — drop the children off at school, get to work, find a location for a new branch office, build a house to live in.

They do not intend to build a city; that just happens.

Even though, along the way, there are many acts of planning, these tend to be local, temporary, or incomplete.

So, ultimately, a city emerges as the collective result of many individual events, most of which are not intended to be city building.

But the acts of planning are intended to guide the development of the city, and these, to be successful, must rely on an understanding of the processes by which the city generates itself.